



Understanding the processes that facilitate and hinder efforts to advance women in organizations

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Abstract

Purpose – Aims to look at the way women in Western industrialized countries have made significant career advancements but barriers remain which necessitate organizational intervention. A number of initiatives that have commonly been introduced to help women in their career development have produced only modest gains in women's advancement.

Design/methodology/approach – Argues that four basic underlying processes – social cognitions, justice, threat, and utility – must be considered and managed as part of the development, implementation, and evaluation of initiatives targeting women's career advancement, if such initiatives are to have their desired impact. These underlying processes and their implications are presented with recommendations for organizational leaders and human resource professionals.

Findings – The goal of women's advancement is both noble and vital to long-term organizational success, and initiatives to further the cause are needed. These goals are not, however, without their obstacles. By understanding how social cognitions, perceptions of fairness, threat, and utility can individually and collectively impact the success or failure of programs to advance women, organizational leaders can develop and implement informed practices that are embraced by all members of the organization and which, consequently, further the advancement of all organizational members.

Originality/value – The article focuses on the key underlying processes that are believed to be critical for understanding the barriers to women's career advancement, but it is necessary to note that, as with any organizational initiative, there are other organizational factors that must be considered, such as top management support, and the history of the organization with regard to gender.

Keywords Women, Career development, Career satisfaction

Paper type Case study

Women in Western industrialized countries including the USA, Canada, the UK, and the European Community, have made substantial progress over the last 30 years in career advancement. Though the amount of attention given to concerns that affect women in the workplace has ebbed and flowed, generally, there have been improvements for working women. Not only have we learned a great deal about the issues, we have also seen growth in women's presence in management fields. This progress, though meaningful, is incomplete.

Despite evidence of greater representation in management in the USA, Canada, the UK, and Australia (Sheridan, 2002), men outnumber women in the high-level, power-base positions in organizations. For example, despite representing greater than 40 per cent of management positions overall in US organizations (US Department of Labour, 2001), membership in board positions or in roles as company officers, is much less common (12.5 per cent, Catalyst, 2001). A similar proportion is found in Canada as



well (11.2 per cent, Catalyst, 2004). Consequently, formal organizational efforts intended to support the advancement of women remain necessary.

Numerous organizational practices have been implemented to address women's inclusion and advancement in organizations. Mattis (2002) presented and discussed several ideas for best practices in this arena including benchmarking on gender, mentoring programs, and a supportive organizational infrastructure. Agars and Kottke (forthcoming) also outlined a number of organizational policies and practices related to gender advancement and diversity management, including creating accountability around diversity initiatives, flex-share programs, and support networks. Some of these initiatives focus on recruiting underrepresented groups into the organization and others are directed toward changing the organizational systems themselves. Ultimately, however, the success or failure of these efforts is dependent on how they are perceived by organizational members – both men and women. If such policies are not embraced by organizational members, they will not solve old problems, and they are likely to create new ones. Lessons learned from the research on affirmative action plans (AAPs) in the USA[1] illustrate this concern. When AAPs are perceived negatively (e.g. unfair, biased, preferential), non-beneficiaries react negatively towards the programs (Highhouse *et al.*, 1999; Slaughter *et al.*, 2002) and towards the beneficiaries (Heilman *et al.*, 1998; Heilman and Blader, 2001). In addition, beneficiaries themselves react negatively and may even doubt their own abilities (Heilman *et al.*, 1987). Even the implementation of policies that are not necessarily directed at the advancement of women specifically, such as “family friendly policies”, have been met, at times, with less than positive reactions (Konrad and Linnehan, 1999). Although there is general evidence that women in management respond favorably to work-family initiatives (Burke, 2001) and there are clear examples of successful work-family policies such as the work/family/life program implemented at the Royal Bank Financial Group (Spinks and Tombari, 2002), there are many other examples where such programs were ineffective, underutilized, or negatively perceived (Konrad and Linnehan, 1999).

As is clear from these examples, the identification of the need for and implementation of successful initiatives is no easy task. In many cases, well thought out programs fail for reasons often unknown to organizational leaders and the human resource professionals charged with their implementation. These programs fail because organizations have not given enough attention to the underlying processes at work in the organizations in which these programs are being implemented. In the initial presentation of our full integration theory (Agars and Kottke, 2004) we identified four underlying processes which we believe to be critical to the implementation of initiatives targeting women and minorities. Better understanding of these processes will lead to better design and implementation of initiatives. The crux of the problem lies in the all-too limited understanding of how organizational members will perceive and respond to gender-based initiatives. We believe that the critical component to the successful advancement of women throughout organizations is understanding and successfully managing the underlying factors that facilitate or hinder the success of initiatives implemented with the intent of furthering the advancement of women.

The identified underlying factors are fundamental social-cognitions, individual perceptions of organizational justice, the threat-rigidity response, and beliefs of practice utility. Although the processes were conceived as pertinent to large-scale

organizational change related to diversity management, their consideration regarding specific practices and initiatives targeting the career advancement of women is no less critical. We believe that if organizations are to introduce effective organizational initiatives targeting the advancement of women, consideration of these underlying processes is essential.

The four underlying processes

Social cognitions

Change is a social process, and the implementation of policies and practices related to the advancement of women is necessarily change-based. Such change efforts are embedded in multiple levels of complex social factors. As a result, in order to effectively integrate gender advancement initiatives, many forms of social cognitions need to be considered. Among the most critical of these cognitions are gender stereotypes and social identity.

Gender stereotypes are strong and persistent, and are generally have more negative impact on women than men in the evaluation of performance (Swim *et al.*, 1989). Though perceptions of men and women have changed over the last several decades, important differences remain in the perceptions of women and men on managerial characteristics (Powell *et al.*, 2002). These perceptions are more negative for women than for men (Schein *et al.*, 1989). Active stereotyping of men and women has historically resulted in fewer opportunities for women, and this use of stereotypes in job decisions remains a concern today particularly for efforts targeting women's advancement. However, not just the presence of traditional stereotypes presents a problem. There has been a change in the manifestation of these stereotypic perceptions of men and women. The distinction between old-fashioned and modern sexism (Benokraitis, 1997; Swim and Cohen, 1997) illustrates how negative attitudes towards women, which were once overt, are now more often manifest in subtle and covert forms. These negative attitudes exist, and remain powerful, but have become more indistinct, have been accepted as normal or exist behind the scenes and are difficult or impossible to observe. Both overt and subtle forms of sexism are real obstacles to women's advancement. Resultant attitudes and behaviors lead to sex typing of jobs (Cejka and Eagly, 1999) and expectations about male superior capabilities for leadership (Eagly *et al.*, 1995; Eagly and Johannesen-Schmidt, 2001; Schein 2001). In more extreme cases, they may lead to organizational cultures in which sexual harassment goes unchallenged. These conditions, resulting from fairly traditional gender stereotypes, must be addressed and managed if advancement efforts are to be successful.

Social identity is another aspect of social cognition that has implications for gender advancement. As described by Tajfel and Turner (1986), individuals perceive themselves to be members of various social groups, and each group membership forms an important part of their individual identity. Gender is a highly salient identity and is likely to be strong. Consequently, most individuals process information from their environment, including facts about organizational initiatives, with some consideration of their gender. The in-group bias and group conflict that can emerge as a function of these identities can create antagonistic perceptions of initiatives targeting women. Conversely, certain group identities, such as ones involving organizational membership, could prove to facilitate gender advancement if motives were

articulated and framed in terms of benefits to the organization as a whole rather than in terms of “women”.

These two important examples represent how social cognitions can impact the gender integration of organizations. Notably, there are both hindering and facilitating properties that must be considered. Of the four underlying processes we note in our model of organizational change, social cognitions represent the most important to women’s advancement as they are integral to so much of the thoughts, behaviors, and attitudes of organizational members, which ultimately determine whether or not any organizational effort succeeds or fails. However, the management of cognitions is but one part of a greater network of underlying processes, and their consideration alone will not guarantee the success of an initiative.

Justice

It is rather ironic that justice perceptions represent a potential obstacle to advancement initiatives. In many cases, justice has been presented as the compelling argument in favor of initiatives that target women and minorities (Kandola, 1994). Unfortunately, real-world perceptions and outcomes often fall short of idealistic principles. Accordingly, it is important to recognize that justice perceptions around efforts towards the advancement of women are often negative. This justice paradox illustrates the conflict between Rawls’ (1971) idea of sociological justice, and the perceptions of procedural and distributive injustice (Greenberg, 1987) that often result when members of the workforce believe women and minorities receive preferential treatment.

The literature on affirmative action plans (AAPs) in the USA, as one example, reveals that many individuals perceive such efforts as unjust (Highhouse *et al.*, 1999; Slaughter *et al.*, 2002). In some cases, state and federal district courts have gone so far as to rule AAPs unconstitutional (Judy and D’Amico, 1999; Elder, 2000). Although the research evidence makes clear that the negative reactions to AAPs are more often perceptual problems than an indication of an unjust AAP, (Kravitz and Klineberg, 2000; Kravitz *et al.*, 2000), the deleterious effect is nonetheless severe for the intended beneficiaries.

It is not only AAPs that affect justice perceptions. Some research evidence suggests that individuals perceive other gender-based policies such as family-friendly policies negatively because they disproportionately address women’s needs (Greenberger *et al.*, 1989). The perception of unfairness associated with these policies may lead men (and some women), at all levels, to resist the implementation of gender initiatives and, ultimately, to resist gender integration. Consequently, initiatives designed to facilitate integration of women may, if not properly managed, inhibit such advancement. In addition, if policies are perceived as unjust, their implementation may create an organizational culture that is hostile towards women. In fact, the backlash experienced by individuals who utilize such programs may make the cost of policy utilization prohibitive.

As has been well documented (Greenberg, 1987; Smither, 1998), fairness perceptions are critical to the success of a wide range of organizational activities and development efforts. Efforts towards gender advancement and integration have the unfortunate distinction of embodying characteristics that lead simultaneously to perceptions that efforts are fair and unfair. Successful management of these perceptions by organizations is critical if advancement efforts are to succeed.

Threat-rigidity

The advancement of women in organizations may also be perceived as a threat both to individual members and to the organization as a whole. To men, an influx of women into management roles represents fewer job opportunities. In addition, policies associated with gender integration threaten promotion opportunities for men and change the environment to which males are accustomed. Many forms of change threaten organizational members and their felt job security. In particular, researchers have examined threat responses to downsizing (Brockner *et al.*, 2001; Brockner and Wiesenfeld, 1996; Wiesenfeld *et al.*, 2000). Change brought about by gender advancement, however, introduces additional threats to self-esteem and masculine identity. On the organizational level, gender integration threatens existing culture, organizational-identity, and stability (Kossek and Zonia, 1993). However, what is of concern to those interested in championing advancement efforts are the consequences.

Threat-rigidity theory (Staw *et al.*, 1981) argues that there is an isomorphic relationship between perceived threat and rigidity of action. Specifically, at the organization, group, and individual level, perceived threat will lead to rigidity in responses including the performance of dominant responses, reduced risk taking, and a narrowing of viewed alternatives for action. In the present context, the perceived threat associated with initiatives targeting women's advancement would lead to increased reliance on gender stereotypes in interactions and in personnel decisions, and limited opportunities for the inclusion of women on projects and in both formal and informal networks. At the organizational level, perceived threat would lead to greater reliance on formalized policies and practices, unwillingness to emphasize developmental efforts, and an absence of support for new policies related to gender, including any among the variety of so-called "family-friendly" policies. As is apparent, each of these rigid responses to the perceived threat makes successful implementation of gender initiatives difficult if not impossible. Unfortunately, perceived threat is a common response to such initiatives, and must be monitored and managed before and throughout a planned initiative.

Utility

Although a psychological perception, the final underlying process is fundamentally an economic phenomenon. The advancement of women is a motivated organizational process. Decisions about the direction to pursue, the effort to put forth, and the persistence with which advancement is sought must be made by organizational leaders. Utility is relevant for virtually every organizational decision (Cascio, 1989); consequently, if gender initiatives are to succeed, their utility must be demonstrated.

Any attempt to explain gender-based initiatives (or any organizational development and change process) would be incomplete if it failed to address utility perceptions. Unfortunately, for the cause of women's advancement, perceptions of utility have been a most powerful obstacle. Few have been able to make a clear case for the financial benefits of gender integration, or even diversity in general. Though several efforts have been made using corporate profits and stock fluctuations (Hillman *et al.*, 1998; Richard, 2000), even the strongest financial evidence is inconclusive. In contrast, the costs associated with policy implementation, negative reactions from current employees, and even those associated with any accommodations that may be needed (e.g., adding women's restrooms) are easily identified. The cost-benefit discrepancy represents a

strong argument against gender initiatives, and it is clear that such lack of demonstrated utility is one reason why organizations are reluctant to proceed. Despite the well-recognized difficulties associated with utility analyses (Latham and Whyte, 1994; Whyte and Latham, 1997), it too is fundamental to the advancement of women within organizations and thus successful gender integration.

To further illustrate the importance of utility, consider earlier evolutions of organizations regarding gender. Why do we no longer see male-exclusive organizations? Much of the initiative for organizations to move beyond the “exclusive” stage was, in large part, the financial cost of discrimination. Organizations who overtly discriminated risked substantial lawsuits. Consequently, organizations initiated efforts to integrate to the extent sufficient to placate a large enough number of individuals, satisfy governmental regulations, and prevent costly lawsuits. Unfortunately, even though modest integration of women may reduce costs associated with lawsuits, the costs of more complete integration may be perceived, as we have already identified, as prohibitive. Thus, perceived utility served initially as a facilitator of advancement initiatives, but on reaching some minimal integration state, utility once again becomes an obstacle to additional advancement efforts. Without demonstrated utility, women’s advancement initiatives will rarely succeed beyond the most basic stage.

Implications and recommendations flowing from these underlying processes

We argue that until these underlying processes are recognized and attended to, initiatives that are intended to help women advance in organizations will fail. We describe next implications of these processes and provide examples of how organizations might incorporate an awareness and understanding of these processes and, ultimately, increase the likelihood that organizational efforts to advance women are successful.

Gender stereotyping

Gender stereotyping has to be addressed and made public with its potential manifestations made apparent through active awareness. Cognitive psychologists have recently popularized the concept of meta cognition, or thinking about one’s thinking. Good use could be made of meta cognition in this context (see Sczesny and Kuhnen, 2004). Decisions and the processes by which they were made must be scrutinized for the possibility that stereotyping played a role. This scrutiny may be as straightforward as reflecting, after a promotion decision has been made, if the same decision would have been made if the targets of evaluation were all male (or all female). For example, in a recent committee meeting attended by one of the authors, a group of college professors were evaluating junior faculty candidates for promotion. One member of the committee asked, after four files had been reviewed, if the committee was requiring women to have higher student evaluations than the men to meet the criteria for excellence in teaching. Making this possibility public pushed the committee to re-think its evaluation process, and resulted in a revised ranking of the candidates. Similarly, in evaluating a candidate for promotion to management, leaders must question whether or not the decision reflects the possibility that the female candidates had to demonstrate greater skill than the male candidates in some aspects traditionally

perceived to be a feminine strength, such as cooperativeness. Alternatively, they must also examine whether or not those skills that are perceived as traditionally “feminine” disadvantage a woman for a management position. Because we know that stereotyping is based largely in unconscious processes, these unconscious thoughts must be made conscious for the decision makers involved, if women’s accomplishments are to be evaluated appropriately and women are to be promoted. Implementing practices that force critical examination and the decision process, and which allow the surfacing of these unconscious thoughts, is critical. Noteworthy, however, is that such processes may make people uncomfortable, and may trigger the threat rigidity process. This possibility only emphasizes the importance of considering the underlying processes within a system of interrelationships, and not independently.

Social identity

Gender as a social identity is a strong marker both for the individual who experiences it first-hand and when viewed by the observer. The implications of this underlying process are twofold. First, the use of gender as a social identity is probably what underlies the success and high satisfaction that women accord to mentoring programs that are gender based (Gray *et al.*, 1995) (i.e. those in which women mentor other women – especially in work settings in which women are the minority). Second, gender identity may be triggered when an initiative proposed by an organization is seen as aimed at women, and sensitization to social identity is likely to trigger feelings of inequity or injustice on the part of men (or even women who believe they had to learn the “tricks of the trade” the hard way). In terms of practical recommendations for this implication, support for programs such as mentoring and networks for women should be tempered with an eye toward examining the reasons for why the mentoring program has been deemed necessary. We are not suggesting the end of mentoring programs for women but are arguing that mentoring programs and the purposes behind them be made more explicit. In other words, we see the typical mentoring programs as an attempt to provide information, guidance, and support that may not be readily available through the normal organizational socialization process. Why is this information and support not made more available to all members of the organization[2]? Perhaps it is not the women who need fixing; perhaps it is the underlying premise of the organization that requires fixing. That is, “fix the women” strategies do not get at the underlying barriers (Anonymous, 2002). If such programs are to be effective for women and accepted by organizational members, their value to the organization as a whole must be clear, or conflict derived from social identities will emerge.

Because we know social identity to be a closely held schema, we cannot hope to challenge individuals’ desires to “flock to the bird of a similar feather;” however, we recommend that organizations in their review of their policies, consider how their policies – well intentioned or not – may activate a dependence on social identity to feel a sense of security or well being. Further, we believe that concerted efforts to foster a strong organizational identity may facilitate (i.e. limit resistance to) the implementation of initiatives that target the advancement of women. In other words, organizations can become better places in which to work for everyone because of initiatives that initially targeted women and minorities (Learson, 1998).

Organizational justice perceptions

As noted, enacted policies within an organization can lead to the perception that one group (or an individual as a representative of that group) has been unfairly treated. Usually, in this context, the issue is that a woman, on the basis of gender has been unfairly given a benefit[3]. Of course, this perspective neglects that the converse can also be true – a woman might be denied a deserved outcome. Women in fact have long decried that they have unjustly been passed over for promotions; certainly the evidence that fewer women achieve top positions in organization supports the core of this complaint (Agars, 2004). In any event, to prevent backlash for any initiative that appears to favor a given group, say women, requires that the organization make explicit the procedures by which decisions are being made. Evidence regarding procedural justice is relatively clear: even when a decision is not in one's favor, if the procedure has been seen as fair, the decision will be accepted (Greenberg, 1987). In the case at hand, advancing women's careers, making certain that the procedures and the criteria are explicit and publicized will allay some feeling of injustice in either camp. Inviting feedback and commentary during the process are also likely to be useful as "voice" is a valuable antidote to perceptions of unfairness (Cawley *et al.*, 1998).

Another way in which fairness can be addressed is by considering the overall effect of a planned policy before implementation. For example, work family friendly policies are typically seen as favoring women and may, therefore, be seen as unfair by men. However, if the overall package of benefits were presented to employees as "benefit" banks in which the individual employee could shift benefits (within legal limits – some health benefits, for example, would need to be set at minimums), the perspective of unfairness would likely diminish. Benefits not needed or desired for childcare, for example, could be put toward personal days taken off.

Threat rigidity

Threat rigidity is an expected response on the part of the male dominated hierarchy to women's advancement. Indeed, it is likely that little change in this hierarchy would have occurred without the passage of fair employment laws mandating gender equality at work. Evidence of threat rigidity can easily be seen in the reaction of top management to the entry of women into their organizations. Women may have achieved entry level positions that are on the traditional tracks to the top of the organization but threat rigidity leads top management – typically a male exclusive club – to conduct less business in the formal setting where women are present and conduct more business in informal venues (e.g. the executive washroom, the golf course).

Because the rigidity is likely to be manifested in gender stereotyping and social identity issues, some of the same recommendations apply. Self-examination and close scrutiny of decisions made and the processes by which those decisions are made are critical. Those within top management and HR need to ask key questions: Are we, as a company or management group, taking fewer risks because we are afraid of offending people? Are we making the criteria and processes by which we are making decisions sufficiently public? If not, why not?

It is important to recognize that the threat rigidity process is not strictly an individual-level phenomenon, but rather, occurs at the group and organizational-level as well (Staw *et al.*, 1981). Consequently, practices and policies that threaten

organizational change, may lead to the organization's reliance on traditional policies such as nepotism in the recruitment and selection process. This temptation, too, must be guarded against when new policies to advance women are introduced.

Utility

Every HR practice can be evaluated for its value to the organization. We understand that the bottom line metric is one of the most powerful to organizations. Dollars, pounds sterling, and euros expended without a resulting benefit are profits lost. At its most basic level, blocking women's advancement in organizations can be expensive because of the legal liability incurred. However, we argue elsewhere (Agars and Kottke, 2004, forthcoming) that one of the difficulties with evaluating any organizational initiative that would benefit women is that of measuring the results. We believe that new metrics are necessary to measure the progress that would result from more women advancing within organizations. Such intangibles include increases in employee job satisfaction and organizational commitment, decreases in turnover and absenteeism, improved work-force capitalization, and greater public goodwill; these intangibles should not be discounted. Some organizations have already made attempts to map attitudes of employees (see Grand Met (Greenslade, 1991); (Sears, White, 1999)) onto profit margins. These are important first steps but we believe more could be done. If we could find a way to measure consistently and accurately these less tangible outcomes, they would matter much more than people realize. Hence, organizations need to develop mechanisms to tie these more elusive perceived benefits of career advancement for women to the bottom line[4].

Conclusion

We have focused on the key underlying processes that we believe to be critical for understanding the barriers to women's career advancement, but we note that as with any organizational initiative there are other organizational factors that must be considered, such as top management support, and the history of the organization with regard to gender. Some of these other factors may interact with the underlying processes, and must be considered before the implementation of a new initiative.

The four underlying processes identified by our full integration theory are presented as critical to the implementation of organizational practices aimed at furthering the advancement of women. The goal of women's advancement is both noble and vital to long-term organizational success, and initiatives to further the cause are needed. These goals are not, however, without their obstacles. By understanding how social cognitions, perceptions of fairness, threat, and utility can individually and collectively impact the success or failure of programs to advance women, organizational leaders can develop and implement informed practices that are embraced by all members of the organization and which, consequently, further the advancement of all organizational members.

Notes

1. Comparable programs exist outside of the USA. In Canada, for example, the Employment Equity Act of 1986 requires federally regulated companies and those with federal contracts over \$200,000 to take steps to increase the representation of women, visible minorities, aboriginal peoples, and the disabled to reflect their proportions in the workforce

- (Calleja, 2001). In the UK, the term “positive action” is comparable to affirmative action in the US and appears to share some of the same stigma and controversial history (Chater and Chater, 1992).
2. See Conger (2002) for a description of how an organization can foster a career development culture for all organizational employees.
 3. Curiously, this complaint usually arises from the group that has most benefited from this very type of action – that is, the white male who has long been the beneficiary of his class and standing in the workplace. See Farr (1988) for greater explanation of the fundamental properties of the “good old boys club”.
 4. Of course, we would have to be fair and also tally the decreases that might be realized in those same variables that may result if feelings of injustice prevailed for men who believed they were not promoted, again demonstrating the need to simultaneously attend to the other underlying processes such as threat rigidity and injustice.

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